Data Analysis Brief

Addressing Disproportionate Gun Possession Charges among Young Black Men in Englewood

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Methodology and Sources

City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset

This dataset contains information about all arrests executed by the Chicago Police Department. Data were downloaded for arrest dates between January 1, 2021 and March 4, 2026 (to reflect a roughly 5-year time period to establish trends in the analysis) and filtered for the target population of interest: Black men ages 18-40 in District 7 (Englewood) with gun possession-related charge statutes. Visualizations were produced using R.

City of Chicago Data Portal, Crimes – 2001 to Present Dataset

This dataset reflects reported incidents of crime that are extracted from the Chicago Police Department's CLEAR (Citizen Law Enforcement Analysis and Reporting) system. Data were downloaded for dates between January 1, 2001 and February 25, 2026. This dataset was merged with the Arrests Dataset by Case Number in order to add specific location information (latitude and longitude) to the Arrests Dataset, allowing for map visualizations produced in ArcGIS.

Cook County Government Open Data, Initiation Dataset

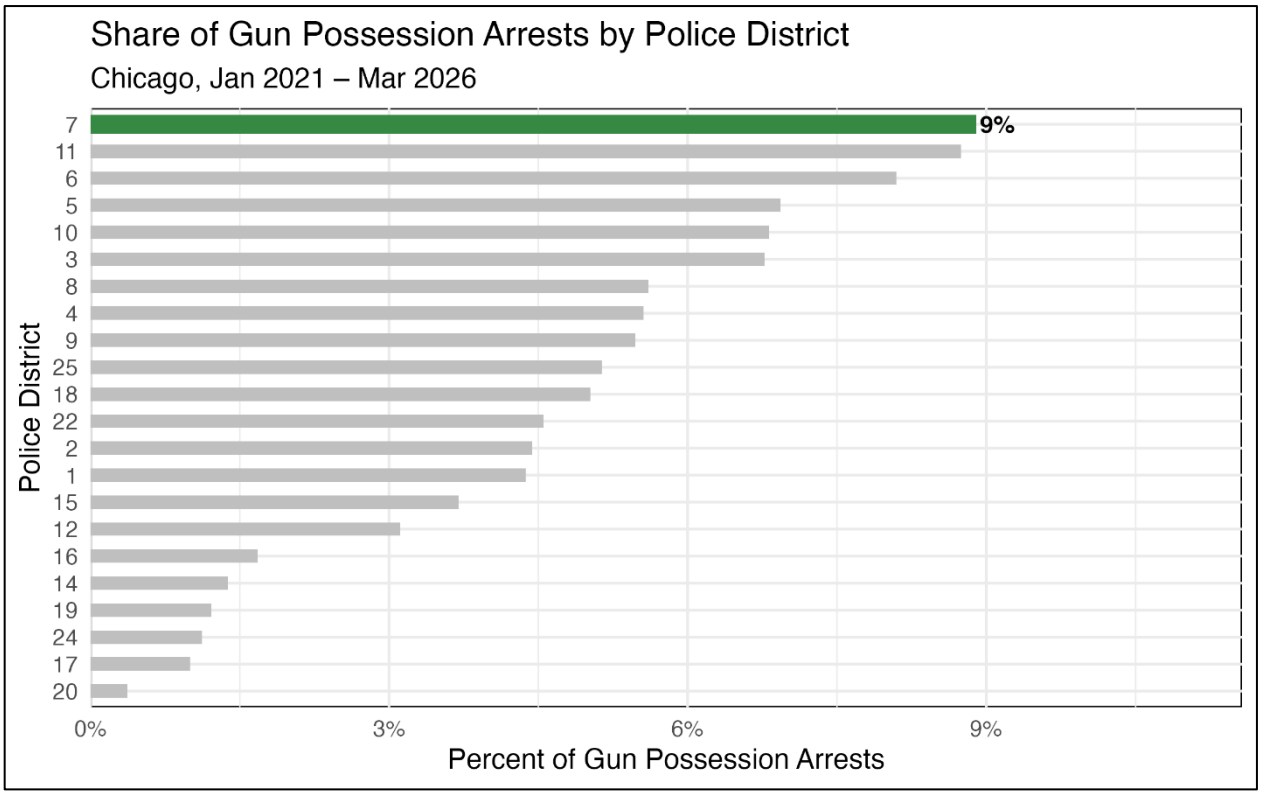
This dataset reflects all of the arrests that came through the door of the State's Attorney's Office. An initiation is how an arrest turns into a case in the courts. Data were downloaded for arrest dates between January 1, 2021, and November 30, 2024, the most recent period for which data were available (data have not been published or collected since December 1, 2024). The dataset was then filtered for Black men ages 18-40 in Chicago with gun-possession-related charge statutes (district-level geographic information was largely incomplete and therefore not used in the analysis). Visualizations were produced using R.

Cook County Government Open Data, Diversion Dataset

This dataset contains information on defendants who receive a referral to a diversion program. Data were downloaded for referral dates between January 1, 2021, and November 30, 2024, the most recent period for which data were available (data have not been published or collected since December 1, 2024). The dataset was then filtered for Black men with gun-possession-related charge statutes (the dataset does not include location data more granular than Cook County or age of the defendant). Visualizations were produced using R.

Figures

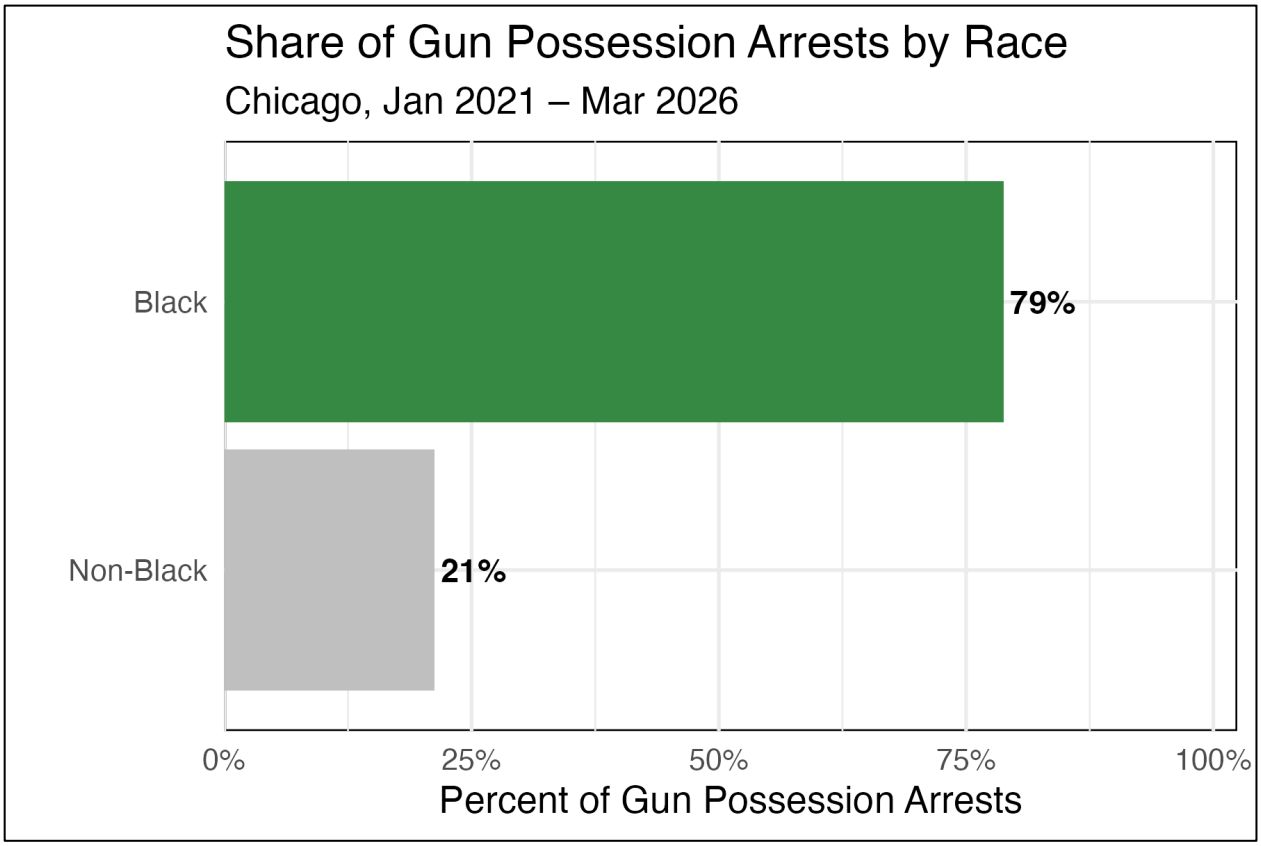
Figure 1. Gun Possession Arrests by Police District in Chicago



Source: City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset

When breaking down gun possession arrests by police district, District 7 (Englewood), highlighted in green, is disproportionately represented: it accounts for nearly 10% of gun possession arrests. This may reflect concentrated police enforcement activity in the area.

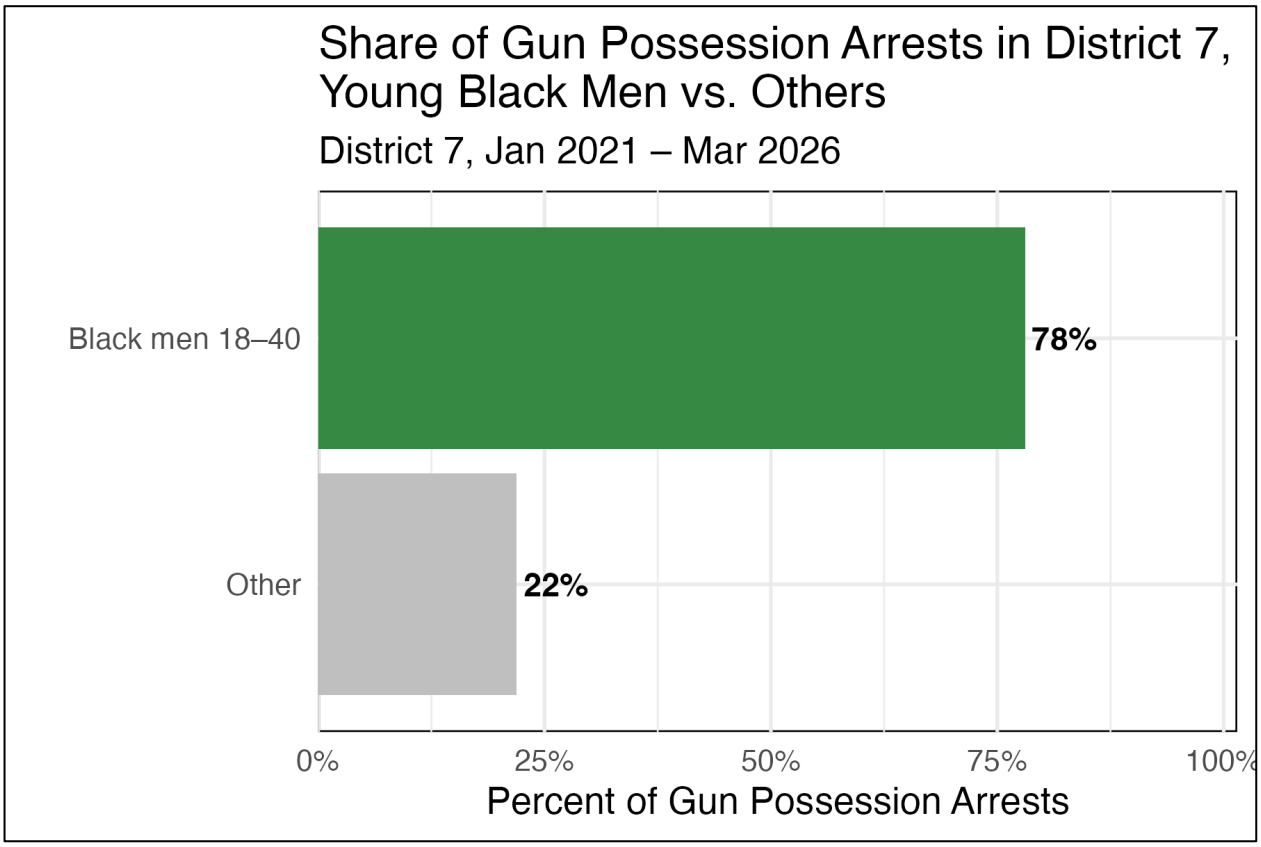
Figure 2. Gun Possession Arrests by Race in Chicago



Source: City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset

A breakdown of gun possession arrests by race across the city shows that Black individuals, highlighted in green, represent a majority of these arrests at nearly 80%. In other words, 4 in 5 arrests in Chicago for gun possession involve Black people, demonstrating racial disparities in enforcement patterns in Chicago.

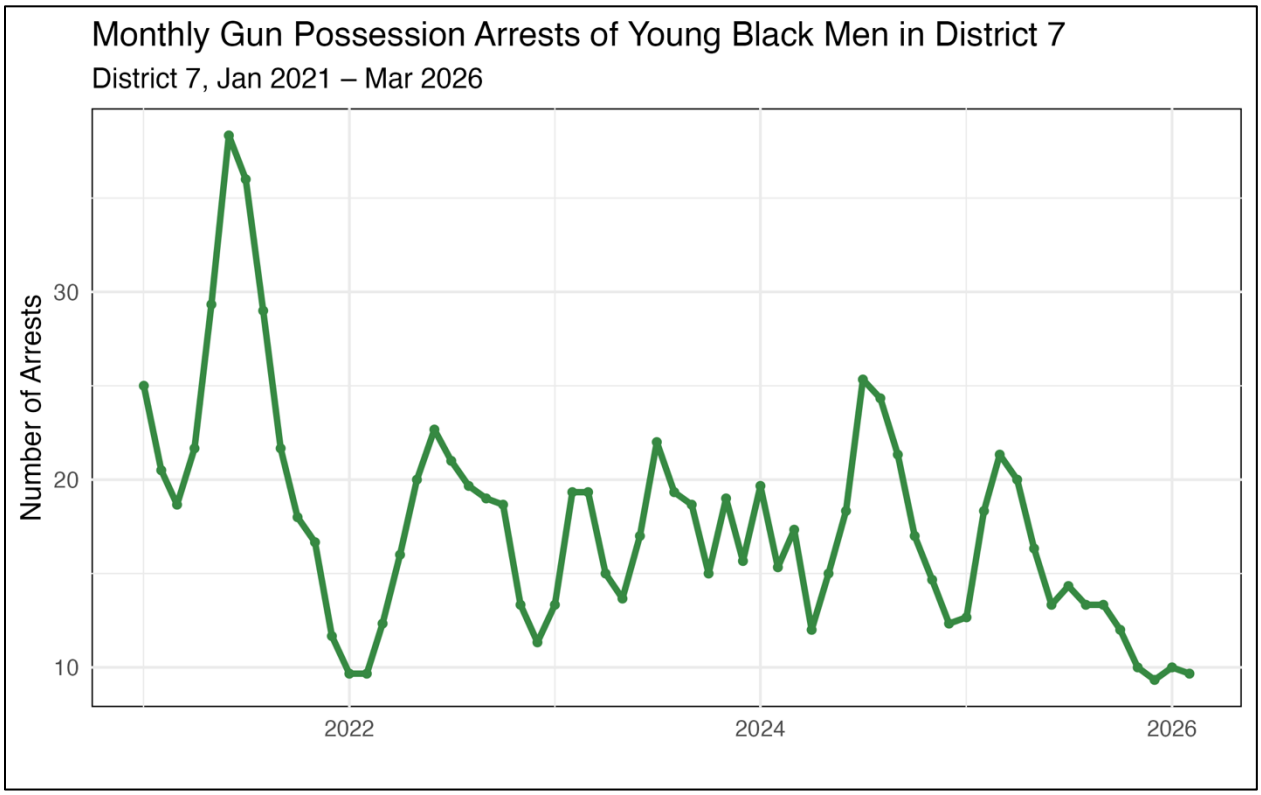
Figure 3. Gun Possession Arrests of Young Black Men in Englewood



Source: City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset

Within District 7, Black men ages 18-40, highlighted in green, represent the vast majority of gun possession arrests within the district. 4 in 5 arrests in Englewood for gun possession involve young Black men (as opposed to women or older men), indicating that police enforcement activity in Englewood is concentrated heavily on young Black men relative to all other demographic groups combined.

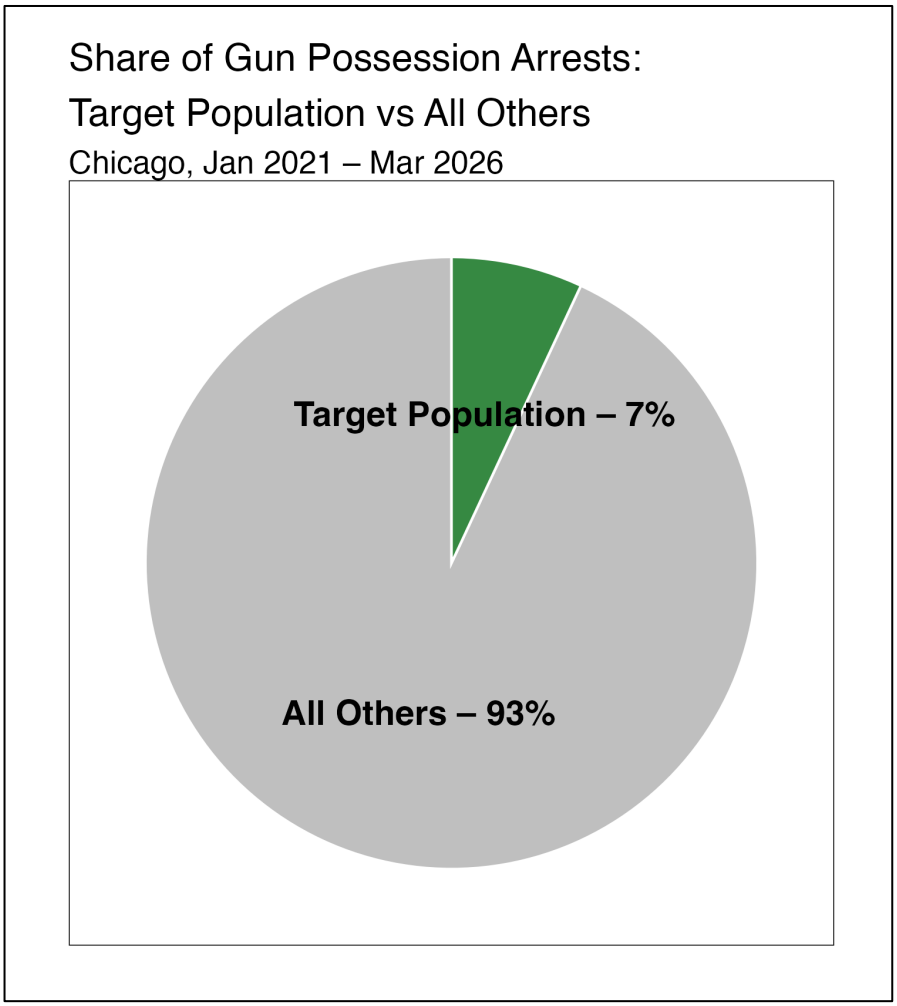
Figure 4. Monthly Gun Possession Arrests of Young Black Men in Englewood



Source: City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset

The monthly number of gun possession arrests involving Black men aged 18–40 in District 7 has fluctuated over time, but it has never dropped to zero in any month, suggesting ongoing police enforcement activity affecting this group.

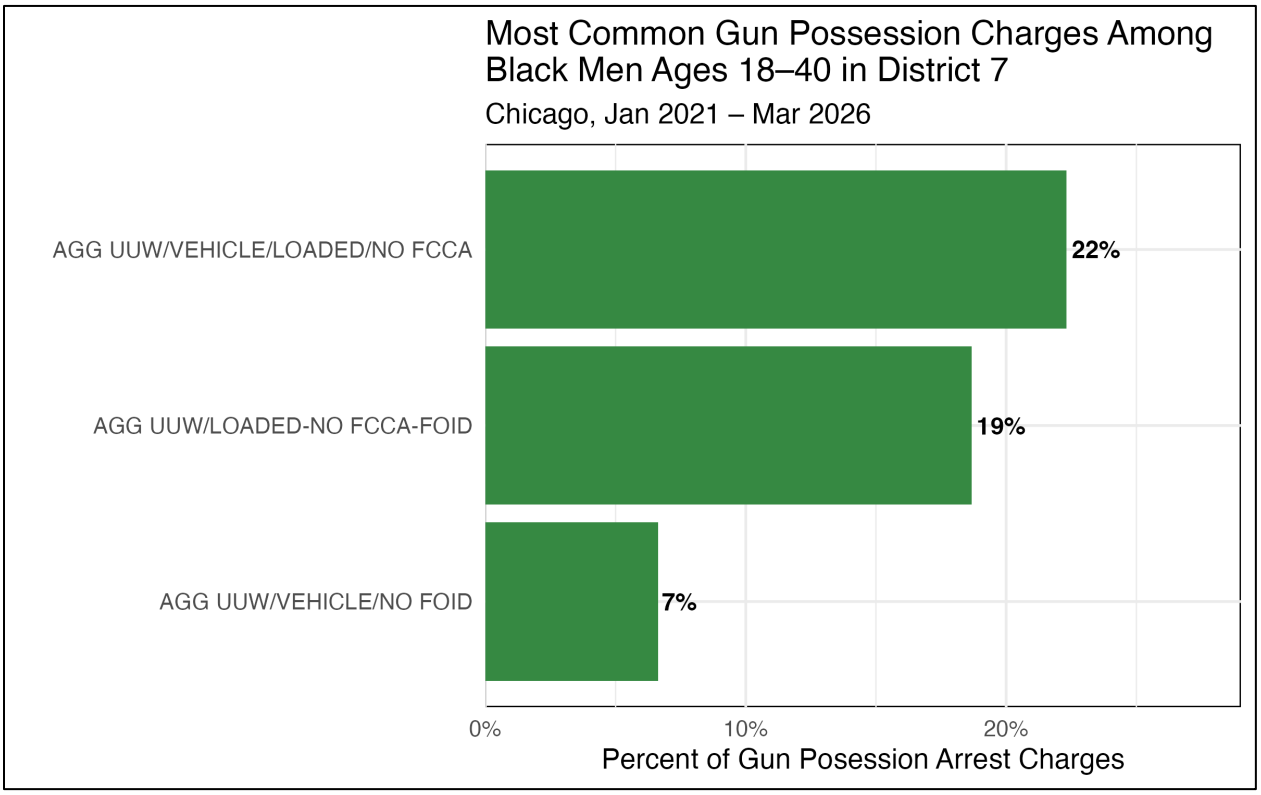
Figure 5. Gun Possession Arrests of Young Black Men in Englewood vs. All Other Gun Possession Cases



Source: City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset

Gun possession arrests involving Black men ages 18-40 in District 7 make up 7% of the city of Chicago's gun possession arrests. Taken together with the previous figures, this highlights how enforcement is concentrated on a specific demographic group within a single neighborhood.

Figure 6. Distribution of Gun Possession Charge Statutes among Young Black Men in Englewood

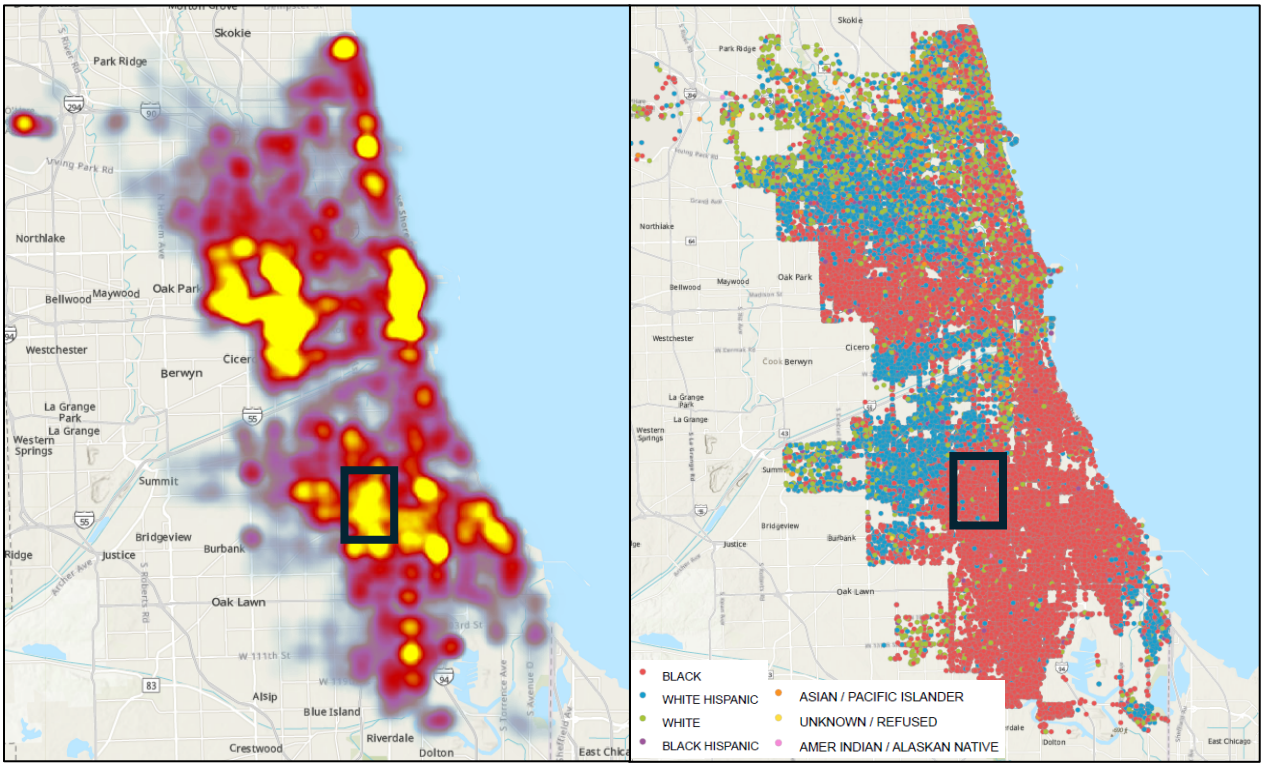


Source: City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset

Black men ages 18-40 in District 7 were arrested under 53 different gun possession charges. The most common charge is AGG UUW/VEHICLE/LOADED/NO FCCA. This stands for Aggravated (AGG) Unlawful Use of a Weapon (UUW) involving a firearm in a vehicle (VEHICLE) that is loaded (LOADED) and carried without a valid concealed carry license under the Illinois Firearm Concealed Carry Act (NO FCCA). The second most common charge is AGG UUW/LOADED-NO FCCA-FOID, which refers to Aggravated Unlawful Use of a Weapon involving a loaded firearm carried without a concealed carry license and without a valid Firearm Owner's Identification card (FOID). Both charges are considered aggravated because the firearm is loaded and immediately accessible. Together, these two charges represent approximately 2 in 5 (41%) of all gun possession cases involving young Black men in Englewood.

Figure 7. Maps of Arrests in Chicago

Density Map (All Arrests) Point Map (Arrests by Race)



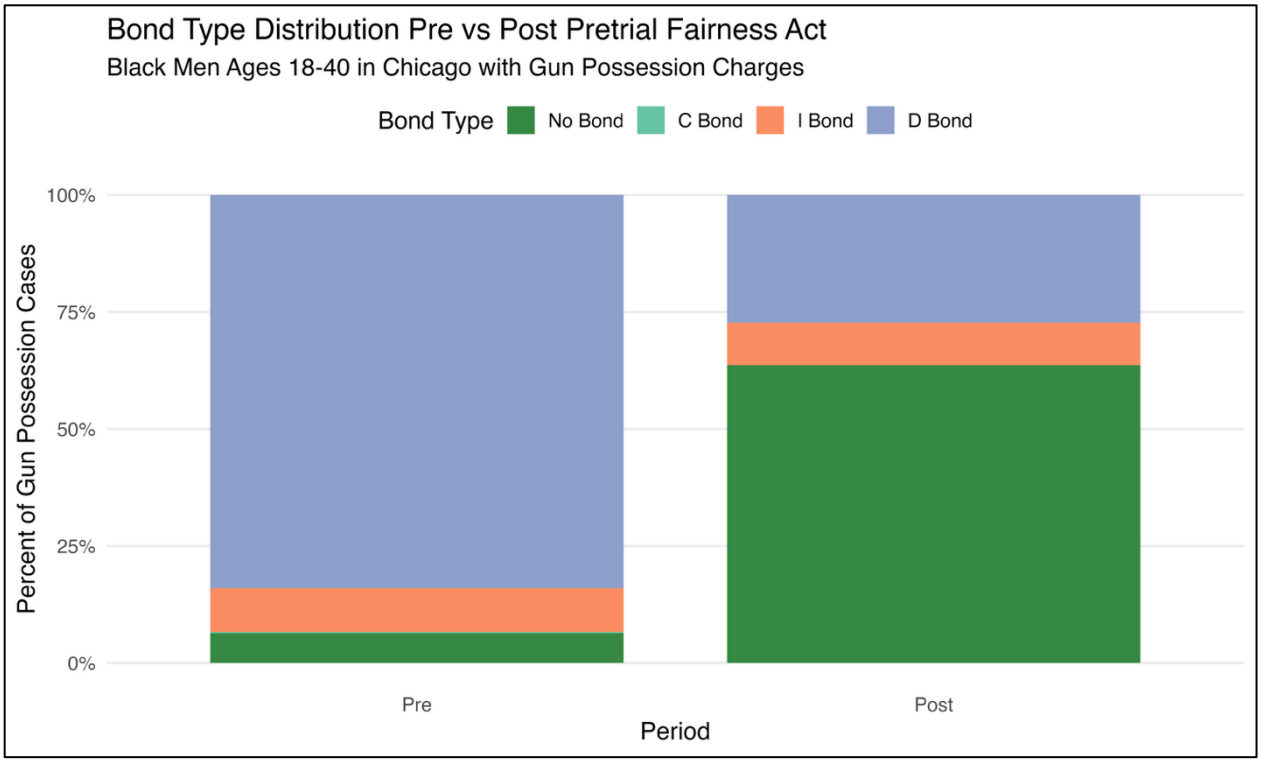
Source: City of Chicago Data Portal, Arrests Dataset; City of Chicago Data Portal, Crimes – 2001 to Present Dataset

The map on the left is a heat map of where arrests happen most throughout the city of Chicago from 2021 through present day. Arrests are concentrated downtown and on the South and West sides of the city. Englewood in particular, denoted by the black box, stands out as having more arrests relative to other areas on the South Side.

The map on the right includes a dot for each arrest in Chicago from 2021 through present day, with each dot colored to represent the race of the person being arrested. Racial segregation is seen throughout the city, with arrests on the South Side primarily involving Black individuals (red dots) and arrests on the West Side primarily involving white Hispanic individuals (blue dots).

Taken together, these two maps illustrate the historical context and modern-day consequences of racial segregation throughout the city and show the high concentration of arrests of Black community members in the Englewood neighborhood.

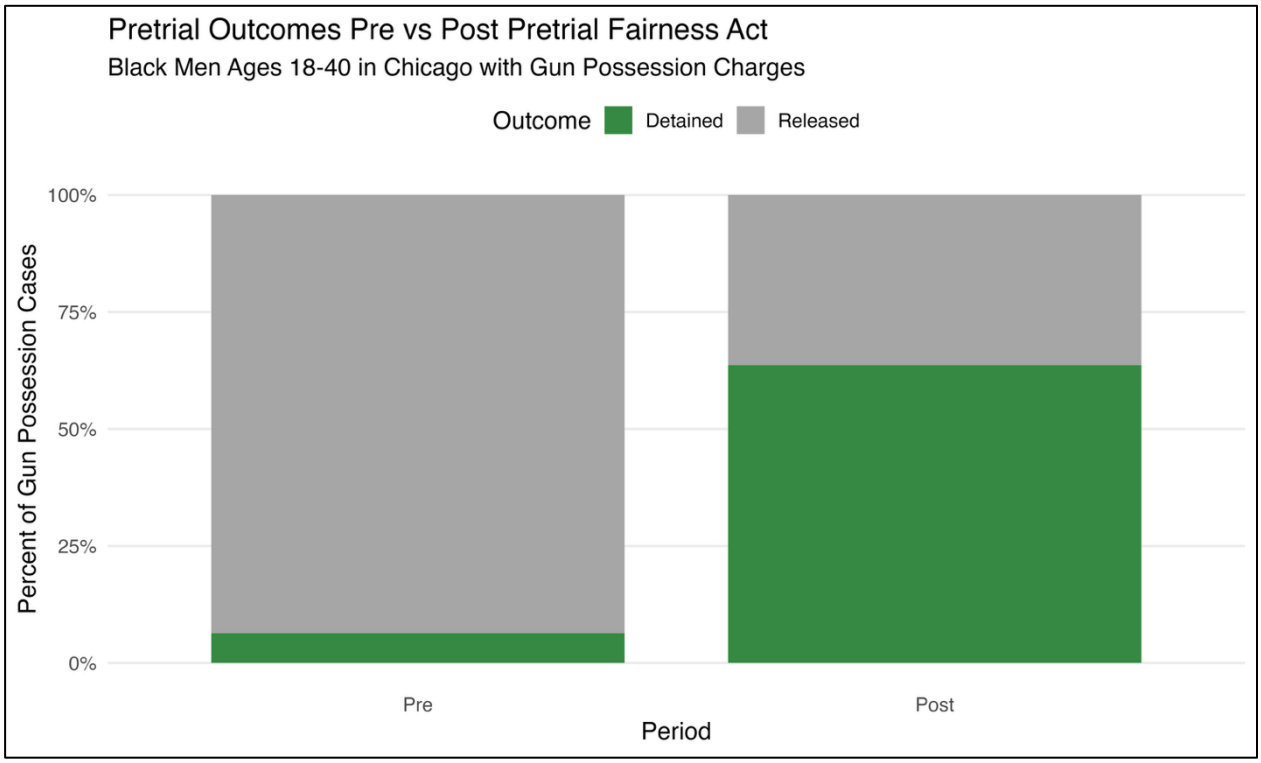
Figure 8. Distribution of Bond Types Before and After the Pretrial Fairness Act



Source: Cook County Government Open Data, Initiation Dataset

The Pretrial Fairness Act (PFA), implemented on September 18, 2023, eliminated cash bail and restructured pretrial detention decisions. Before the PFA, cases could be assigned individual (I), cash (C), deposit (D), or no bond; I, C, and D bonds allowed release, while no bond resulted in pretrial detention. After the reform, only I bonds or no-bond outcomes were possible. This bar chart shows cases between October 11, 2022, and July 17, 2024, for Black men ages 18-40 in Chicago with gun possession charges. As expected, C and D bonds dropped sharply post-reform, with a few D bonds (purple) persisting due to cases initiated before the enactment of the law. The share of no-bond outcomes (green) increased by ~60 percentage points, while I bonds (orange) remained largely unchanged. This suggests that although the elimination of cash bail removed financial barriers to release, judges may have substituted monetary bonds with greater reliance on pretrial detention.

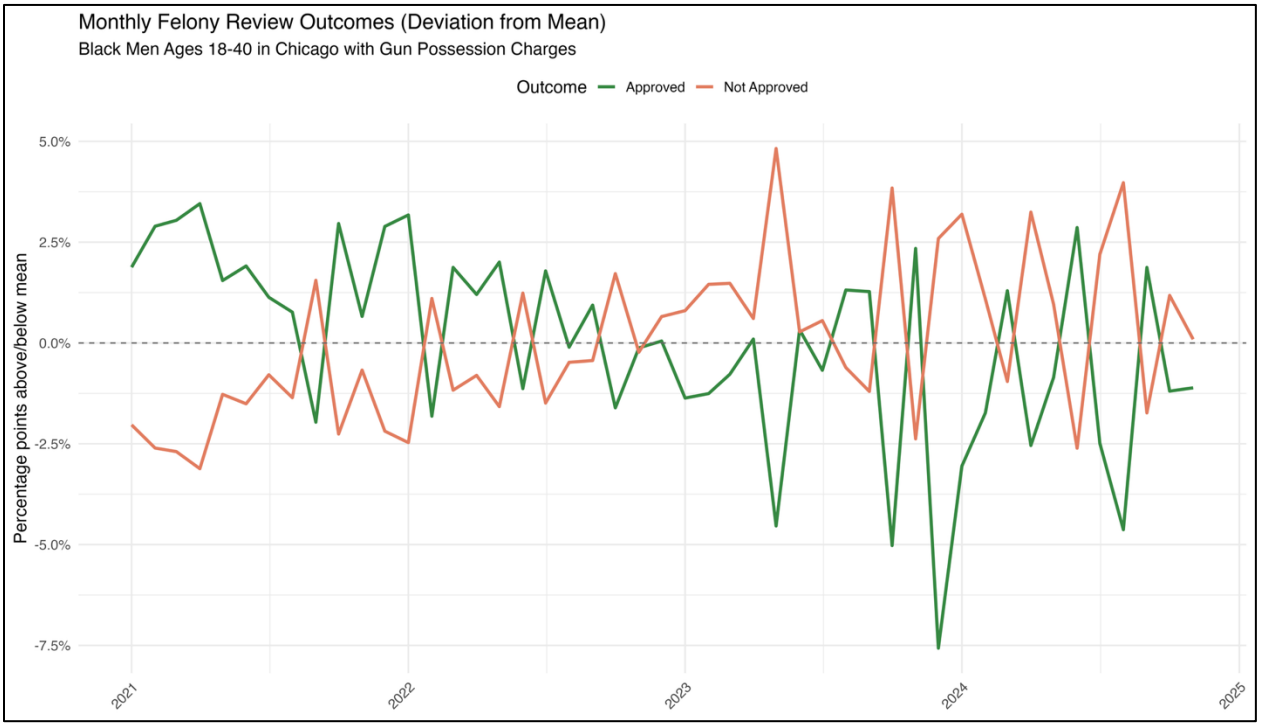
Figure 9. Distribution of Pretrial Outcomes Before and After the Pretrial Fairness Act



Source: Cook County Government Open Data, Initiation Dataset

This bar chart collapses I, C, and D bonds into "Released" (gray) and recodes "No Bond" as "Detained" (green), focusing on the key distinction between release and pretrial detention. After the Pretrial Fairness Act, detention rose by nearly 60 percentage points while release declined by a similar amount, showing that eliminating cash bail may have had unintended consequences on pretrial incarceration.

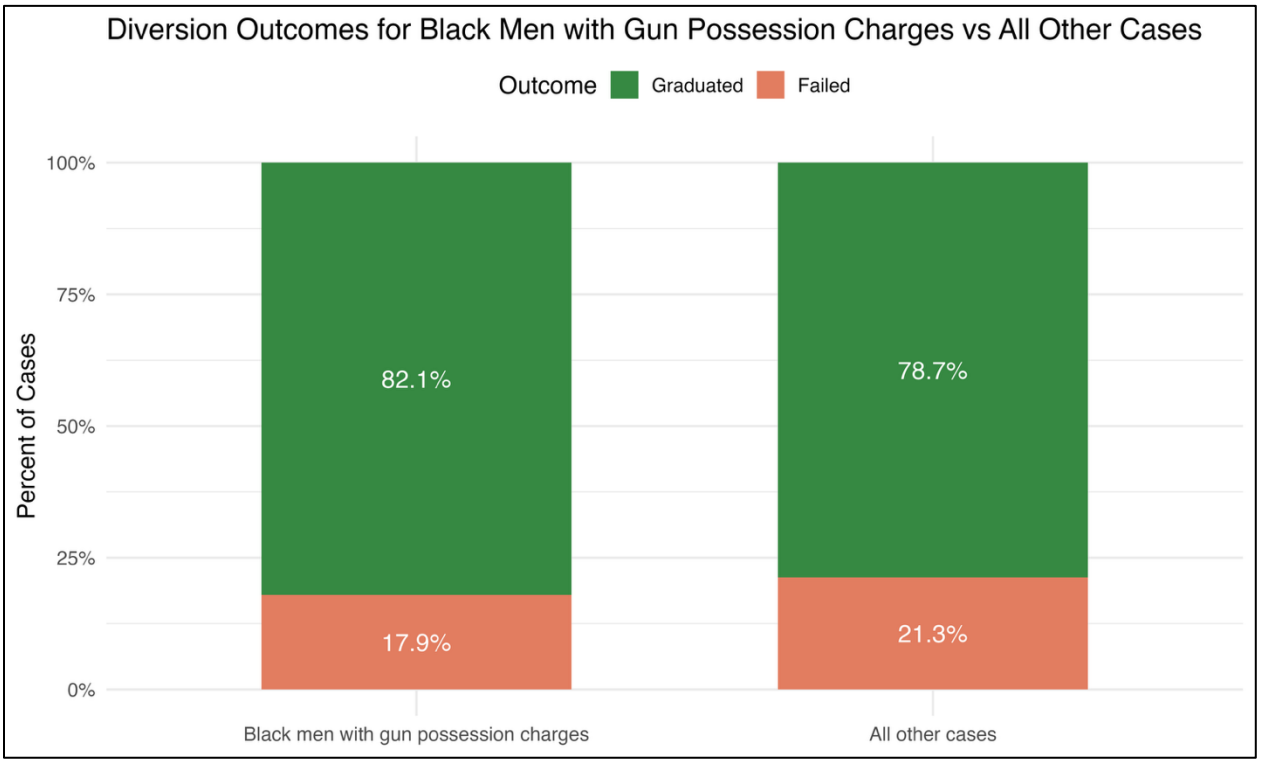
Figure 10. Outcomes of Felony Review



Source: Cook County Government Open Data, Initiation Dataset

The Felony Review Bypass Program was first piloted in Englewood in January 2025, allowing responding police officers to file certain gun possession charges directly instead of waiting for approval from the Cook County State's Attorney's Office. In late 2025, the program was expanded citywide. This visualization examines felony review outcomes from January 1, 2021 to November 30, 2024 for Black men ages 18-40 in Chicago with gun possession charges, grouped as Approved (green) and Not Approved (red), where "Not Approved" includes cases that either had continued investigations or were fully rejected. The chart shows deviations from the monthly mean, so peaks in the red line indicate months with above-average continued investigations and rejections, meaning that fewer cases were being approved through the felony review process. Notably, 1,570 cases were not approved during this period, suggesting that bypassing felony review could allow a substantial number of cases that previously were not approved to proceed directly into court, raising concerns about fairness and pretrial decision-making.

Figure 11. Outcomes of Diversion Programs



Source: Cook County Government Open Data, Diversion Dataset

Cook County diversion programs provide alternatives to prosecution for certain offenses, aiming to reduce incarceration and connect participants with supportive services. In 2025, the RJCC diversion pathway for gun possession was temporarily suspended and reinstated in 2026, and Illinois SB 1899, enacted in 2026, introduced a FOID diversion program allowing participants to maintain or obtain a FOID card while in the program. Of the 3,299 cases with a defendant enrolled in a diversion program between January 1, 2021, and November 30, 2024, 195 (approx. 6%) were for Black men with gun possession charges. This visualization compares diversion outcomes between this target population and all other cases (all other races, genders, and charge types) over this period. Green indicates cases that successfully graduated, while red indicates cases that failed. Notably, the data shows that Black men with gun possession charges graduated at slightly higher rate than all other cases, highlighting the efficacy of targeted diversion pathways for this demographic and suggesting that, when provided with structured support, these participants are navigating these programs with greater success than the broader diversion cohort.